PRIORITY 22 OF 33 · SCORE 2.7

Social Security Administration

SSA pays more benefits than any agency but publishes almost nothing at the payee level. Its error rates are low for retirement benefits and high for Supplemental Security Income (11.6%). The most useful public-data role for SSA is as a supplier: its death records are what other agencies (OPM, PBGC, CMS) are missing when they pay dead people. Approach SSA as a data partner first and a target second.

INVESTIGATIONS WE PROPOSE

- **SSA-1** County SSI and disability outliers adjusted for age and health. **First prototype.**
- **SSA-2** Facilitator networks of attorneys, doctors and payees across charged cases.
- **SSA-3** The death-data case, sized from OPM and PBGC findings.

EXPOSURE

- SSI: $7.3B improper (11.6%). Disability Insurance: $2.3B. (GAO, FY2025)
- PBGC credited a pension plan for 3,479 deceased participants because it did not check SSA's death file, overpaying about $127M (2023).
- GAO found FEHB paying about 400 providers for services dated at least 50 days after their death (2026).

PUBLIC DATA WE USE

- **SSA State and county statistics:** beneficiaries and payments by program and county; SSI recipients by state and county.
- **SSA OIG audits and investigations:** representative payee and disability fraud cases.
- **Disability fraud cases** from DOJ and the Cooperative Disability Investigations units, as labeled examples.

HOW WE DETECT IT

1. **Geographic outliers:** counties where SSI or disability rolls and award rates are far above peers after adjusting for age and health.
2. **Facilitator networks:** attorneys, doctors and representative payees who recur across charged disability cases.
3. **Death data gaps (cross-agency):** quantify how much other agencies' payments could be stopped with full death data.

SCORECARD

Fraud savings identified
● Pending

Phase 1 window
Weeks 10–13
Jan 18, 2027 to Feb 12, 2027

Workstream
Aggregate screens and access cases

FY2026 outlays
$1.66T · budget rank 3

Leads go to
SSA OIG, Anti-Fraud Programs, Do Not Pay

WHY PRIORITY 22

Exposure	●●●●○
Public data	●○○○○
SBA method fit	●●○○○
Actionability	●●●●○

FIRST PROTOTYPE

A county-level SSI and disability outlier map, paired with a one-page case for SSA death data sharing built from the OPM and PBGC findings.

OUR REVIEW, DELIVERED WEEK 13

County SSI and disability outlier map from SSA state and county statistics, adjusted with ACS age and disability and CDC PLACES health data; facilitator network from charged disability cases (attorneys, doctors, representative payees recurring across cases). With PBGC and OPM results, write the cross-agency case for death data sharing.

Every lead goes to an Inspector General or DOJ as a referral package with sources and caveats. Nothing is published.

WHAT WE ASK OF SSA

Phase 2 data: Payee and representative payee data, disability claims, full death file.

What it enables: Facilitator rings; payee abuse; death data for other agencies.

Access route: SSA OIG; CDI units.

LIMITS

No public payee-level data, and full death data sharing is restricted by law. This brief is mainly a data-access proposal.

SOURCES

- GAO-26-108694: FY2025 improper payments
- PlanSponsor: PBGC overpaid Central States $127M for deceased participants
- GAO-26-108139: FEHB paid deceased and excluded providers
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)

Scores and plans are our judgment from public sources. Risk indicators are leads for Inspectors General or DOJ, not accusations.

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